

Chapter 30 - Drunk

"Sorry"? Chu Qingqiu actually said "sorry"?

Ning Fuyi's heartstrings suddenly trembled, and more than half of her drunkenness sobered. Her gaze fell on the woman's profile—half of her hair covered her forehead, her eyelashes cast black shadows on her cheeks, and her nose was touched by moonlight, beautiful like a pure white lotus under the moon.

"What did the Divine Venerable say?" Ning Fuyi asked. She suddenly felt curious, wondering who could make her abandon her pride and utter such an apology.

Just as her words fell, Chu Qingqiu suddenly opened her eyes. Those eyes were crystal clear, staring straight at her, as if there was no trace of drunkenness.

Ning Fuyi was startled and instinctively tried to straighten up, but a hand suddenly gripped her shoulder with such strength that it firmly fixed her in place.

"Qiu Yi¹." Chu Qingqiu spoke, her voice very calm and her gaze clear. If she hadn't called the wrong name, Ning Fuyi would have thought she was pretending to sleep earlier. "I told you to fetch wine. Why have you returned?"

"Are you now refusing to listen to me as well?" Chu Qingqiu said coldly, forcefully pushing Ning Fuyi's shoulder away and picking up the empty wine pot from the table to shake it. "You two, one after another, all have no conscience."

Who has no conscience? Ning Fuyi was pushed back two steps, knowing that Chu Qingqiu had mistaken her for Qiu Yi, and was momentarily speechless.

But she had never seen Chu Qingqiu drunk before. Such a person seemed able to bear everything herself, not needing wine to help solve her troubles.

"Bai Lin²." Chu Qingqiu called again. She stood up to look for Bai Lin, but stepped right over the white tiger's belly. Ning Fuyi frowned but suddenly wanted to laugh—so even when drunk, Chu Qingqiu was just like ordinary people.

Only the poor little white tiger suffered, struggling with its limbs and blowing bubbles.

Chu Qingqiu's figure drifted around the room in a circle. Her wide white robes were lifted by the wind from outside the window, as if draped in pure white moonlight. After searching around without finding Bai Lin, she gave up and sat back down at the table.

"Go fetch wine," she commanded in a low voice.

"She already went to fetch it," Ning Fuyi replied.

"Who went to fetch it?" Chu Qingqiu turned around and asked.

"Uh..." Ning Fuyi had never dealt with drunk people before, so she began to talk nonsense: "Bai Lin."

Unexpectedly, Chu Qingqiu actually believed her. She made an "oh" sound and threw the empty wine pot aside, sitting upright with proper posture: "Then this venerable one shall wait."

She must have had too much to drink, Ning Fuyi thought. She actually found this serious-faced yet nonsense-talking Chu Qingqiu somewhat... cute.

As soon as these two words popped into her mind, she fiercely pinched herself. This word had nothing to do with Chu Qingqiu at all. The word "cute" could be used to describe anyone, but definitely not this stone-hearted old immortal in front of her.

She suddenly remembered why she had come here, so she raised her arm and waved it in front of her: "This dress—did you make it?"

Since Chu Qingqiu was drunk, she was too lazy to pretend to be obedient and use honorifics.

"What dress? Qiu Yi, how dare you! How can you address your master so casually?" Chu Qingqiu was about to furrow her brows when Ning Fuyi quickly added "Master" to the end of her words, and only then did she close her red lips.

"Ning Fuyi's dress," Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes narrowed slightly as she pretended to be Qiu Yi.

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu responded readily.

"Why?"

"This venerable one wanted to make it, so I made it. What's there to question?" Chu Qingqiu scoffed lightly.

Even with confused thinking, she was still this annoying. Ning Fuyi let out a long breath, wanting to take advantage of this rare opportunity to ask more riddles, so she continued: "Is it really because of Condensing Heaven³ Sect Master's dying wish that you repeatedly help her?"

"Master," she quickly added.

"This venerable one helps when I want to help. What need is there for reasons?" Chu Qingqiu said again.

This mouth was truly tight-lipped. Ning Fuyi immediately felt deflated and no longer fantasized about getting anything out of her. Just then, footsteps came from behind. Qiu Yi ran up carrying two jars of wine with both hands, panting heavily.

"Ning Fuyi?" She exclaimed in surprise, then lost her pleasant expression and defensively blocked in front of Chu Qingqiu. "What are you doing here!"

Before Ning Fuyi could hastily make up a reason, Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke: "This venerable one ordered you to fetch wine. Why did it take so long to come up!"

Qiu Yi's shoulders immediately trembled. She turned around with the wine jars and lowered her head: "Reporting to Master, there's no wine in our palace. The two jars you just drank were my only remaining collection..."

"And the sect prohibits disciples from drinking wine. This disciple asked all the way to Elder Yuan Ming's quarters before obtaining these two jars of apricot blossom wine." As Qiu Yi spoke, she didn't hand the wine jars to Chu Qingqiu. Instead, she carefully said, "Master, please drink less. After all, your body..."

She instinctively glanced at Ning Fuyi and didn't finish her words.

But Ning Fuyi caught the last word she revealed—body? What was wrong with Chu Qingqiu's body?

"Bring it here." Chu Qingqiu didn't listen to her and simply said softly. Although Qiu Yi was unwilling, she never dared to disobey Chu Qingqiu's orders and could only take small steps forward to place the wine jar on the table.

However, just as Chu Qingqiu's hand gripped the wine jar, a figure appeared beside her, raising five fingers to press down on the jar. Chu Qingqiu's movements paused, and she blurted out: "Who are you..."

"I am Ning Fuyi." Ning Fuyi said in a low voice, her hand firmly blocking the wine jar. "You can't drink anymore."

"You—when did you start caring about Master?" Qiu Yi mocked from the side. "Save it. How could Master ever listen to you..."

Before she finished speaking, she opened her mouth wide in surprise, watching with her own eyes as her supremely noble Divine Venerable nodded and obediently let go of her hand.

Qiu Yi pinched herself and let out a "hiss."

Ning Fuyi had also never expected that Chu Qingqiu would actually listen to her. Her hand froze on the wine jar for a moment before she took it from the table and casually placed it aside.

She turned back to look at Qiu Yi, who was also staring at her. The two faced each other and, for once, didn't quarrel. Finally, Qiu Yi looked away first and stepped forward quietly: "Master, it's getting late, and you've been drinking. You should rest."

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu nodded. She stood up and walked toward the bed. Her wide hem trailed behind her, and her snow-white bare feet appeared and disappeared beneath the hem. She quietly sat on the bed and lay down.

Qiu Yi stepped forward and respectfully pulled down the bed curtains for her, then retreated. Ning Fuyi also planned to leave with her, but her wrist was suddenly grasped by a hand—the palm was burning hot, as if it had fine sweat.

Then, from within the curtains came words that only she could hear, extremely careful:

"Sorry, Ning Fuyi."

The fellow disciples outside the screen were chattering noisily about something. The coming and going figures were reflected on the screen. Perhaps because the selection took place yesterday, this morning's Pearl Light Pavilion was noisier than usual.

Ning Fuyi lay on her bed with her eyes open, staring at the caisson⁴ above painted with the Nine Heavens Mysterious Woman⁵. The wine had long since worn off, but she had been sleepless all night.

Last night's events still replayed in her mind, disturbing Ning Fuyi's thoughts tremendously. The clothes that Chu Qingqiu had personally sewn were still on her body, clean and well-fitted.

When the mind was overused, it inevitably recalled some long-forgotten past events, such as the first time she saw Chu Qingqiu. She was still a child then, carried to Purple Mist Peak by Ning Changfeng⁶ and shamelessly left for Chu Qingqiu to look after.

As soon as he put her down, she was frightened into wailing by one look from Chu Qingqiu, crying so hard she nearly fainted. In the end, Ning Changfeng had to hurriedly carry her away.

Before leaving, she clearly heard Chu Qingqiu coldly say she was "timid and cowardly, with no talent whatsoever."

As a child, the person she feared most was Chu Qingqiu. At that time, she didn't know what kind of existence Chu Qingqiu was in the eyes of the world—she only knew that her gaze was terrifyingly cold. No matter how miserably she cried, there was never half a trace of concern in those beautiful peach blossom eyes.

Later, she no longer dared to cry in front of her. When she saw Chu Qingqiu, she would be many times more obedient than usual, but even so, she never received Chu Qingqiu's direct attention.

She knew Chu Qingqiu disliked her, so when she grew older, this dislike transformed into rebellion. Every time she was forced to see Chu Qingqiu, she would put on a thoroughly thorny and rebellious appearance.

Then came Ning Changfeng's death, and this rebellion became hatred. This hatred grew stronger with each disaster.

However, even in her previous life, even at the very end—before Chu Qingqiu eliminated her for the sake of all living beings—although she had captured and tortured Chu Qingqiu, she had never thought of killing her.

Not even a tiny bit.

A night of thinking made her mind even more chaotic. Ning Fuyi suddenly got up, abandoning all her thoughts.

She couldn't think anymore, lest it delay important matters.

Before walking out of the screen, she looked down at the dress she was wearing and, after a moment's hesitation, suddenly untied the sash and pulled it off, casually stuffing it into the bedside cabinet, then changed into a black silk dress she usually wore.

After feeding the spinning Peace⁷ on the ground, she petted Peace's head, let it play by itself, then walked out of Pearl Light Pavilion.

The disciples who saw her along the way whispered among themselves, but whenever Ning Fuyi cast her gaze their way, those whispers would disappear.

Ning Fuyi sneered inwardly. Without listening, she knew what they were discussing—nothing more than spreading rumors that she had used underhanded methods to defeat Li Chao'an⁸.

She strode alone through the crowd when a wooden bird suddenly flew before her eyes, opening its mouth with Elder Ping Yao's⁹ voice: "The Swaggering Convention¹⁰ has been moved up. Pack your belongings and come to Cloud Deep Hall¹¹ immediately."

The Swaggering Convention moved up? Ning Fuyi was stunned.

After the time of one incense stick, Ning Fuyi had already appeared at the entrance of Cloud Deep Hall. Dozens of disciples had already gathered here, wearing the robes of the East, West, South, and North courtyards respectively. Ning Fuyi stood among them, somewhat out of place.

"Yiyi¹²." Liu Wenzhu¹³, wearing light blue courtyard robes, came flying on her sword from the horizon, stopping beside Ning Fuyi with the wind. Her fair little face was flushed pink with urgency. "I went down the mountain to collect items sent from home and almost missed it."

She jumped down from her spirit sword, unable to hide her excitement: "I thought it would be several days before we departed for Swaggering Mountain¹⁴. I didn't expect it to be so soon."

"Oh, that's right." She mysteriously leaned close to Ning Fuyi's ear: "I heard from the Liu family's message that this Swaggering Convention is very different from previous ones. They told me to make more preparations."

Ning Fuyi nodded upon hearing this. At this time, everyone had arrived and stood in formation, waiting for arrangements.

She roughly scanned the group—more than half were unfamiliar faces. Leading them was a tall, square-faced man from the East Courtyard, the managing disciple of the East Courtyard named Hong Ying¹⁵. He was holding a roster and counting people. When he pointed to Ning Fuyi, his gaze lingered on her for a moment without saying anything, then turned to Liu Wenzhu beside her: "The North Courtyard disciples have shallow cultivation and have never traveled far from home. Therefore, the elder has ordered me to arrange for a disciple with high cultivation to lead you. You must follow her these days and not act alone."

"Feng Ge¹⁶." He turned and pulled a woman from the crowd. The woman had almond eyes and crescent moon brows, precious spirit jade hanging around her neck, also wearing the blue and white robes of the East Courtyard. Golden leather gleamed at her waist as she stood before Ning Fuyi.

"Senior Sister Feng Ge." Liu Wenzhu bowed to her, and the woman smiled and returned the courtesy.

Liu Wenzhu pulled Ning Fuyi, so she also bowed, but the woman acted as if she hadn't seen her, turning to stand beside Liu Wenzhu, waiting for Elder Ping Yao.

Liu Wenzhu's dark brows furrowed as she looked worriedly at Ning Fuyi, but Ning Fuyi just shrugged at her, indicating she didn't care at all.

All the disciples had arrived and summoned their spirit swords to hover beside them. Those accompanying this trip were Elder Ping Yao, Elder Jing Shan¹⁷, Elder Yuan Ming¹⁸, and Mei Chengsi¹⁹. Chu Qingqiu's figure was nowhere to be seen.

Ning Fuyi found that her gaze was unconsciously searching for Chu Qingqiu, so she frowned and suppressed her actions, lowering her head to adjust her sash.

"By the way, the areas around Swaggering Mountain are all sacred grounds. Only spirit beasts or sword flight are permitted entry—flying eagle boats²⁰ cannot be used. The journey is long and passes through many desolate miasma lands. Your cultivation levels make sword flight difficult to reach there." Feng Ge spoke while waving her hand to summon a sword that was pure white throughout. "So Liu Wenzhu, you'll ride with me."

"What about Yiyi?" Liu Wenzhu, seeing her repeatedly ignore Ning Fuyi, couldn't stand it anymore despite her good temper. "She..."

"My sword cannot carry two people." Feng Ge answered curtly, her gaze carrying a trace of contempt. "As for her, she'll have to find another way."

Ning Fuyi frowned and was about to say something when she heard a voice behind her—cold and familiar.

"She'll come with me."

Footnotes:

1. **Qiu Yi (秋亦)** - A disciple who serves Chu Qingqiu, literally means "Autumn Also"
2. **Bai Lin (白麟)** - The white tiger spirit beast, literally means "White Qilin"
3. **Condensing Heaven (凝天)** - Name of the sect/mountain gate where Ning Changfeng was the sect master
4. **Caisson (藻井)** - A decorative ceiling panel, often found in traditional Chinese architecture
5. **Nine Heavens Mysterious Woman (九天玄女)** - A goddess in Chinese mythology associated with war, sexuality, and longevity
6. **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's adoptive father and former sect master, literally means "Ning Long Wind"
7. **Peace (平安)** - Ning Fuyi's pet, likely a small animal or spirit creature
8. **Li Chao'an (李朝安)** - A disciple Ning Fuyi recently fought, literally means "Li Morning Peace"
9. **Elder Ping Yao (平遥长老)** - An elder of the sect, literally means "Elder Peaceful Distant"
10. **Swaggering Convention (招摇大会)** - A martial arts convention/tournament, literally means "Swaggering/Boastful Great Meeting"
11. **Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿)** - A hall within the sect, literally means "Deep Cloud Palace"
12. **Yiyi (衣衣)** - Liu Wenzhu's nickname for Ning Fuyi, playing on the "yi" in her name which means "clothes"
13. **Liu Wenzhu (柳文竹)** - Ning Fuyi's friend, literally means "Liu Literary Bamboo"
14. **Swaggering Mountain (招摇山)** - The mountain where the convention is held
15. **Hong Ying (洪影)** - The East Courtyard managing disciple, literally means "Hong Shadow"
16. **Feng Ge (冯歌)** - An East Courtyard disciple, literally means "Feng Song"
17. **Elder Jing Shan (景山长老)** - A sect elder, literally means "Elder Scenic Mountain"
18. **Elder Yuan Ming (元明长老)** - A sect elder, literally means "Elder Original Bright"
19. **Mei Chengsi (梅承嗣)** - A person accompanying the trip, literally means "Mei Inheriting Heir"
20. **Flying eagle boats (飞鹰舟)** - Magical flying vessels shaped like eagles